

Spicy Caramelized Leeks with Fresh Lemon

YIELD — 4–6 servings

I want to use this platform to issue a formal apology to leeks: Leeks, I've been ignoring you for years, almost always choosing literally any other allium over you. I'd like to think that those years of neglect were all in preparation for bringing us to this very moment, when you take center stage, shining in a dish that can only be described as "better than it ought to be," given the limited number of ingredients involved.

Here, leeks sizzle in a spicy olive oil mixture, the wild tendrilly ends crisping up like they've been deep fried, looking like an extremely festive and delicious party decoration; the pale green center becoming impossibly tender and creamy, finished with a bright raw lemon. If there was a dish to make you feel bad for ignoring leeks all this time, this is it. Don't worry—they forgive you!

Ingredients

4 large leeks, dark green parts removed, halved lengthwise
1/3 cup olive oil
2 tablespoons harissa paste
Kosher salt and freshly ground black pepper
1/2 lemon, seeds removed, very finely chopped
Flaky sea salt

Preparation

1. Preheat the oven to 450°F.
2. Place the leeks cut side down and, without cutting through to the root, slice them lengthwise into 1/4-inch strips. (You'll have a leek that looks like a streamer or palm fan). Place leeks in a 9 by 13-inch baking dish or on a rimmed baking sheet.
3. Whisk the olive oil and harissa together, then massage into the leeks, getting into all their layers. Season with salt and pepper and lay them straight-ish.
4. Roast, without disturbing too much so that they keep their long, wild shape, until they start to fry and sizzle and brown at the ends, 20 to 25 minutes.
5. Remove from the oven and transfer to a serving bowl or platter. Top with the lemon and flaky salt before serving.

DO AHEAD: Leeks can be roasted several hours before serving, then kept loosely covered at room temperature. No need to reheat them before serving (they'll stay crispy and are good at room temperature), but you can if you like.